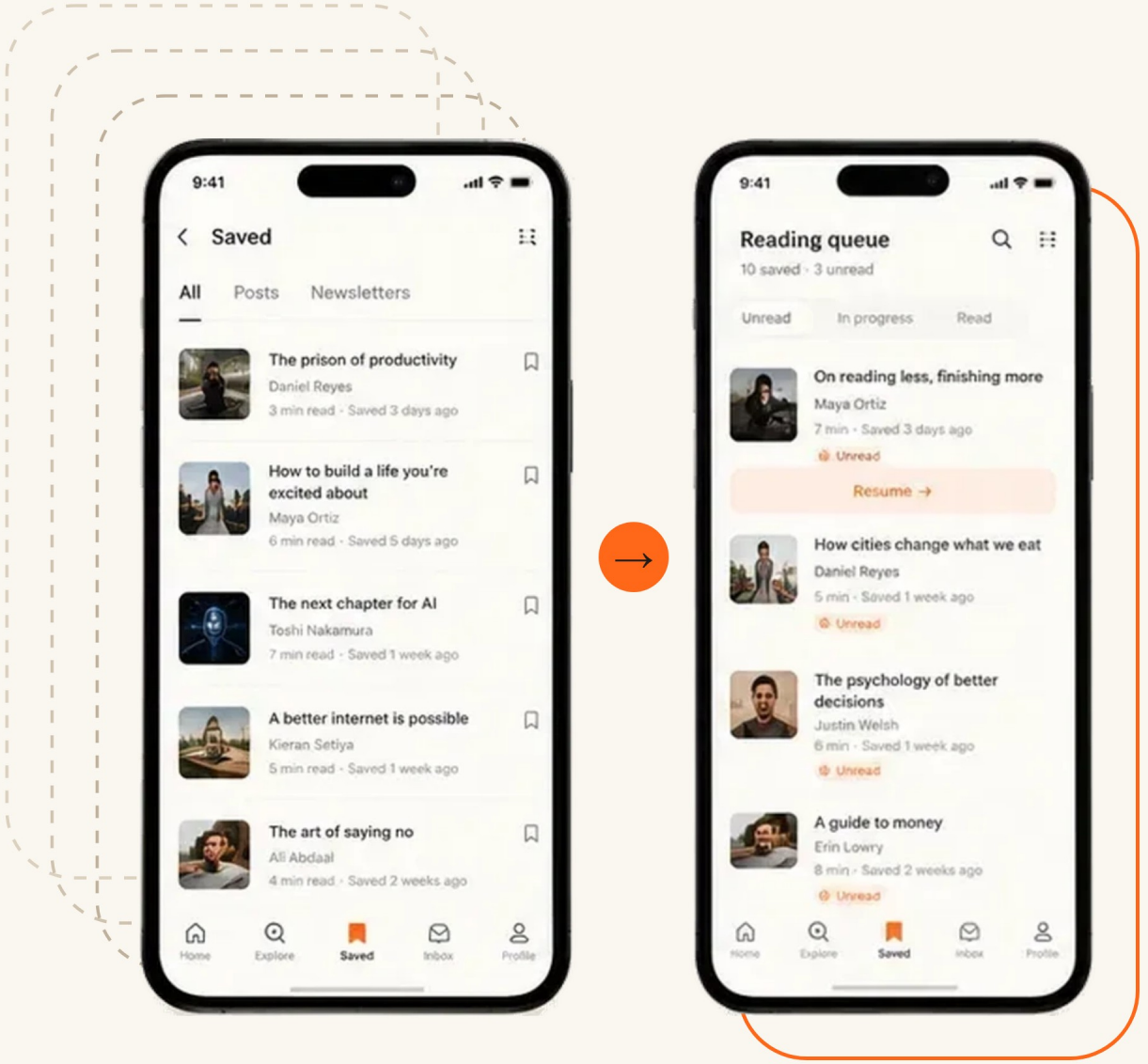
PRODUCT CASE STUDY · SUBSTACK

Saved for later.
Forgotten forever.

Readers save articles with every intention of returning. The opportunity: help them actually read what they saved.



Today: saved, then buried

Proposed: saved, then read

Where the reading journey breaks

01

Discover

An interesting article appears in an Instagram post, an email newsletter, or the Substack feed

→

02

Save

One tap. The intent is real; the commitment is zero.

→

03

Get distracted

Messages, meetings and the next thing take over.

→

04 · THE BREAKDOWN

Forget

I remember the topic, but not the exact article.

Nothing brings the saved intent back. **Source: my own habit of saving posts, a personal observation, not validated research.**

THE PRODUCT INSIGHT

Saving captures intent. The product should help turn that intent into action.

Saving takes one tap. Reading takes minutes, attention and a moment that never arrives on its own.

Assumptions to validate

- **Personal observation.** I remember topics, not exact articles.
- **Assumption.** Readers save more than they read.
- **Assumption.** Forgetting, not lost interest, is the main cause.
- **To test.** A gentle reminder beats none, without raising opt-outs.

Substack Reading Assistant: three parts, one loop

1 · SAVE · TEST FIRST

Personal reading queue

A calm home for saved, unread articles with reading times and progress.

→

2 · RETURN · TEST FIRST

Smart reminders

Gentle, user-controlled nudges that resurface an article at a useful moment.

→

3 · UNDERSTAND · TEST LATER

Optional AI reading assistant

Voice and text help inside the article: explain, summarize, answer, give examples.

SECONDARY CONCEPT · SCREENSHOT DISCOVERY

Upload a post seen elsewhere and Substack looks for the exact article. If no match can be verified, it says so and offers related results.

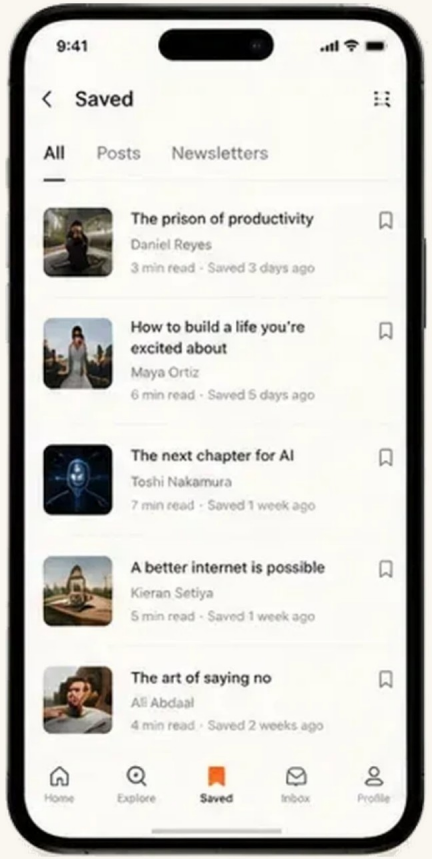
substack

From saved articles to actual reading.

The Substack experience you know, with a smarter way to keep up with what you save.

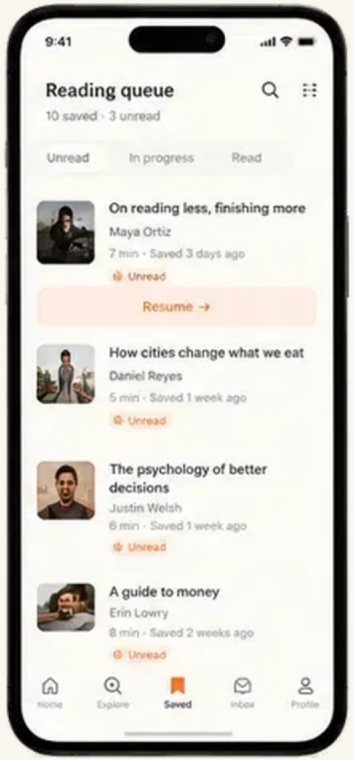
Today

Saved articles get buried.



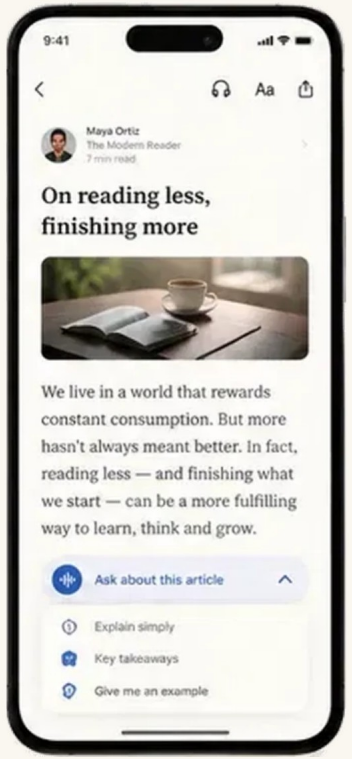
Proposed solution

A dedicated reading queue, contextual reminders and an AI assistant, all within the Substack experience.



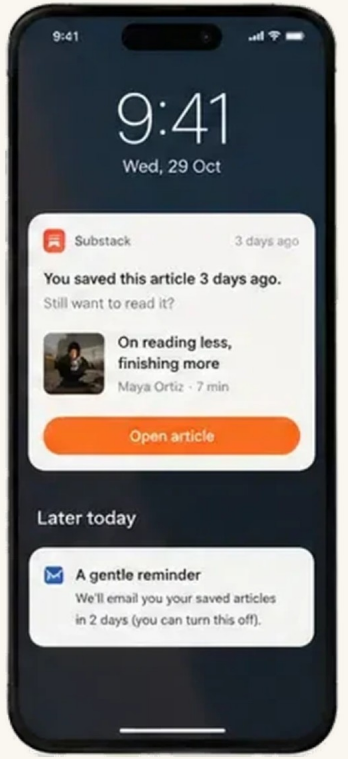
1 Reading queue

Saved articles, time left, one-tap resume.



2 Optional AI help

Explain, summarize or give an example.



3 Smart reminders

Nudges you control, in app or email.

The bigger picture

We are not just adding features. We are helping readers turn saved intent into real reading, while staying true to the simple, focused Substack experience.

What to test first

Start with the smallest experiment that tests the core user problem.

01		TEST FIRST **Reading queue**	Make saved, unread articles visible and easy to resume.	*Do more users return to read what they saved?*
02		**Contextual reminders**	Resurface unread articles at useful moments.	*Do reminders increase reading without annoying users?*
03		**Voice assistant**	Help readers understand difficult articles through voice or text.	*Do readers want explanations while reading?*
04		**Screenshot discovery**	Find articles from screenshots of posts discovered elsewhere.	*How often do readers struggle to find content discovered on other platforms?*

Why this order? The reading queue tests the core problem with less implementation complexity. Reminders build on that foundation. AI features follow once user demand is clearer.

How I would validate it

We believe making saved articles visible and easy to resume will help readers finish what they saved. We are right if saved-to-read conversion rises without opt-outs rising.

1
Hypothesis
Readers forget saved articles
Evidence: assumption

2
Prototype
Queue and one gentle reminder
Evidence: concept

3
Small user test
Watch how readers respond
Evidence: qualitative

4
Controlled rollout
A small group vs. a control
Evidence: behavioural

5
Decision
Expand, adjust or stop
Evidence: all of the above

PRIMARY METRIC

% of users who read at least one saved article within a defined period

SECONDARY

- Saved-to-read conversion
- Article completion
- Repeat readership

GUARDRAILS

- Notification opt-outs
- Email unsubscribe rate
- Reminder dismissals

DECISION RULES

Expand: more reading, guardrails hold.

Adjust: readers return, opt-outs rise.

Stop: no lift after iterating.

Help readers finish what they were already interested in.

BUILD FIRST

Reading queue + reminders

Make saved, unread articles visible in one place. Show reading time and let readers resume where they left off.

Decision

Tests the core problem without building complex AI features.

VALIDATE NEXT

Does it change behaviour?

Test whether readers return to saved articles and actually read them.

Metrics

Saved-to-read conversion, article completion, repeat readership.

Guardrail

Notification opt-outs and unsubscribes.

EXPAND IF VALIDATED

Make reading easier

If readers return but struggle with long or complex articles, test an optional voice assistant that explains key ideas and answers questions.

Decision

Expand only if research identifies a real need.

WHAT I'D LEARN NEXT

Understand why readers drop off

- Do readers forget, run out of time, or lose interest?
- When does a reminder feel helpful rather than intrusive?
- Do they want help understanding articles, or simply finding time to read?